Hyderabad AI meet calls for national open datasets to power India AI

India's AI challenge is not compute scarcity but the absence of truly open, high-quality training datasets, experts said at a discussion organised by the Software Freedom Law Centre at IIIT Hyderabad, calling on the India AI Mission to prioritise public data collection over GPUs.

"My primary focus for the IndiaAI Mission would be to put all the money, first of all, into collecting data," one speaker said.

The Mission has allocated ₹ 103.72 billion over five years, with this year's outlay cut to ₹ 10 billion from ₹ 20 billion, and only ₹ 8 billion utilised last year. Speakers argued the structure is ineffective. "It's not even a drop in the ocean, compared to megacorps in the US and China," one said, adding that long procurement cycles leave hardware outdated.

Instead, India faces a severe shortage of language data. "Everybody is starved of data. And the way out they're taking is using synthetic data," a speaker noted, warning this leads to "bad data" and "a bad model." Even Hindi lacks adequate, dialect-sensitive coverage.

Experts proposed a government-led effort to crowdsource datasets through teachers and public institutions. "Eight thousand samples of questions, answers, and reasoning—can't we get 8000 samples… in Telugu or Hindi? Is that so hard? It's not."

They also criticised "openwashing". "Nobody provides you the training data," one said, stressing that true open source must include data, documentation, and workflows. Frameworks such as the Model Openness Framework were recommended, while Stable Diffusion was cited as an example of fully open AI.

"We have the first thinking car, which reasons about why it is doing something." Huang added that the technology can be deployed rapidly worldwide.

Open source software helps build detailed 3D map of Chandrayaan-3 landing site

An independent Indian researcher has demonstrated that mission-grade lunar mapping no longer needs to remain confined to space agencies. Using publicly available Chandrayaan-2 imagery and open source tools, Germany-based Chandra Tungathurthi has built a high-resolution 3D terrain map of Shiv Shakti Point, the Chandrayaan-3 Vikram lander's touchdown site near the Moon's south pole.

The work resulted in a Digital Elevation Model (DEM) with roughly 30cm per pixel resolution, detailed enough to capture terrain shape, slopes, depressions, craters, and boulders, and to support rover path planning and safe landing analysis. The model was generated from Orbiter High Resolution Camera stereo image pairs using photogrammetry techniques. Tungathurthi spent months building an open processing pipeline, while the final computation alone ran for over 24 hours on a high-performance computer.

Explaining the value of elevation data, Tungathurthi said, "An OHRC image tells you what the surface looks like. A DEM tells you what the surface actually is," adding, "Over the past several months, I spent considerable time understanding how Chandrayaan-2 data is organised and released. During this process, I realised that recent advances in open source tools have made it possible to independently generate high-resolution elevation maps of the lunar surface."

India talks open source but runs on closed AI APIs, says Activate survey

India's AI startup ecosystem may speak the language of open source, but production reality tells a different story.

A survey by venture firm Activate covering 244 CTOs, developers, and founders finds 74% of deployments rely on proprietary Western models accessed through APIs, while only 13% customise or train their own models and just 13% use open source models. As the report states, "The 'open source India' narrative doesn't match what's actually running in production."

Infrastructure use reflects this dependence. 65% of GPU capacity goes to inference, compared with 21% for training and 14% for fine-tuning. "The majority of this ecosystem is calling APIs, not training models," the report notes.

Cost pressures reinforce the trend. 60% spend under $2400 per month, making local training uneconomical. "Investing in training infrastructure makes less sense every month when you can ride the capability curve by calling an API."